hedge against the domination of a single power. The Ukraine war and the weakening of China's ally, Russia, means a more cautious and restrained posture on the part of China as its sense of vulnerability gets heightened. This should create some breathing space for India.

The most dramatic changes are taking place in Europe. The European response may have surprised Russia and China, and perhaps the Europeans themselves. There has been an unprecedented and remarkably cohesive response from both the European Union as well as NATO. The change in Germany has been dramatic. It has shed its post Second World War inhibitions to assume a much more active role in European affairs. From a European economic superpower it is likely to become Europe's strongest military power too. It is now committed to a higher defence expenditure of over 2 per cent of its GDP for the foreseeable future. It has breached its earlier taboo of not supplying lethal arms to conflict zones by doing so for Ukraine. And this has been achieved by a left-leaning coalition government. Germany was the one country which had maintained a more balanced policy towards Russia, promoting economic interdependence and political engagement. This has now changed, perhaps irretrievably, and it is likely that Germany will lead the coalition against Russia. It is also significant that the European Union, which has always projected itself as an economic arrangement, has taken on a visible security role by financing defence assistance to Ukraine.

The perception of enhanced threat from Russia means that there will be less patience in Europe with China's alliance with Russia. China's ability to work on divisions within Europe will be more limited.

The US has seen some dent in its deeply polarized politics, but an overall bilateral political consensus still eludes President Biden. However, on Russia there is broad support for Biden and for the imposition of sanctions on Russia. The threat held out for imposition of follow-on sanctions on China, should China assist Russia in evading them, also enjoys support. But the US will be careful not to provoke a serious confrontation with China. The objective would be to keep heightened pressure on China, increase its sense of vulnerability and add to its perception of constraint. China will